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DEPARTMENT OF MOLECULAR, CELL AND DEVELOPMENTAL
BIOLOGY ORTHOPAEDIC HOSPITAL RESEARCH CENTER
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February 1, 2026

Diana Rigueur
801 Hilgard Avenue
Hershey Hall 312
Los Angeles, Ca, 90095
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Dear Distinguished Teaching Committee,

It is with great pleasure that I write this letter of support for Mr. Isaias Roberson for the Distinguished Teaching Award, in the category for Teaching Assistants.

I am a Distinguished Assistant Researcher and Lecturer with dual appointments with the department of Molecular, Cell & Developmental Biology and the Biomedical Research Minor. Christian was an extremely driven and creative Teaching Assistant in my upper division course MCDB 144 Molecular Biology during the Spring of 2023, 2024, and 2025.

I met Isaias three years ago, when he first started his Teaching Assistant position in the Spring of 2023. I was blown away by his natural charisma, his ability to communicate with his students and to understand their needs without compromising rigor of the material. It was clear that he had a knack for teaching. He was a joy for Spring of 2024, and 2025. **In the MCDB major, it is unusual for a graduate student, a PhD candidate to teach more than twice.** However, Isaias is on his 4th TA-ship and will have his last (5th) with me in the Spring of 2026. Although his lab is heavily funded, Isaias is the only one having to work for his PhD. Isaias received an NIH-supplement award that paid his tuition. Due to grant funding changes, he lost his NIH award. However, I have never seen him happier. Isaias loves teaching.

Isaias designed jeopardy games for review of upper division Molecular Biology without compromising intellectual complexity of the material. His students really connect with the material, have so much fun. **Isaias's students usually score at the top of the class.** He held additional office hours for all students and led the other TAs through three very successful teaching quarters. **Isaias also TAs for my colleague Austin Nakano**, who teaches the course as a **reverse classroom**. Although the topics are similar, the reverse classroom setup is distinct to my own, as a didactic instructor. In some ways, the reverse classroom should be seen as a distinct course, due to a complete reversal and slight difference in subject manner than what I present. The reverse classroom is a new way of learning and given that Isaias does not have autonomy for the courses he teaches, he has done an incredible job teaching his students. Isaias wrote additional supplemental notes to help his students comprehend topics, a whole set of 18 distinct notes. These students enjoyed the course more than previous years. That is **an example of Isaias's devotion to his students and the long-term impact he will have on them, learning beyond the classroom.**

Isaias is an exceptional TA. I hope his efforts are recognized in this letter and his other materials. If there are any questions, feel free to contact me at any time via email or call my office at (310) 794-9489, or preferably due to COVID, my personal home line at (714) 603-9930.

Sincerely,

Diana Rigueur

Diana Rigueur, PhD
Molecular Cell & Developmental Biology Faculty
University of California, Los Angeles

Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award 2026 Application: Narrative Statement
Isaias Roberson
Course: MCD Bio 144

About a week after my first quarter of being a teaching assistant ended in the spring of 2023, a student emailed me saying that "I am proud to say I am no longer afraid of research papers." She described how the environment of my discussion section licensed her to say "no, I still don't understand this concept" when her other experiences taught her to simply nod and agree with the instructor, even if she didn't understand. I will always carry her comments with me, as the transformation from being scared to being confident, from being passive to actively engaging with knowledge, is my goal as an instructor.

As students arrive in upper-division biology, many still believe science means recalling long-worded cellular processes to fill in blanks on exams. While this might have helped them previously, they are making a transition from taking standardized tests to practicing science. My job is to get students to function intellectually as scientists and develop skills that serve them whether or not they pursue science professionally.

In my discussion sections, I do not lecture. Instead, my mode of operation is the Socratic method, where students and I engage in dialogue, where we both ask and answer questions. When students ask questions about papers or assignments, I guide them in interpretation, identify points of confusion, and put them back onto the path of understanding rather than providing answers. I understand this can feel uncomfortable. One student noted that I "will lead [them] to think instead of just telling [them] answers." I view this discomfort as normal and productive. I am trying to create an environment where admitting confusion is safe and where saying "I don't understand" acts as the start of learning, rather than something that a student should feel punished for. This approach leads to students consistently saying that they felt they could participate even when they "weren't entirely confident in [their] answers."

As a scientist who is instructing students, it is also my job to model critical engagement with primary literature. This includes questioning authors' conclusions and showing students that no one—not me, not the authors—has the final word. It's our job to evaluate what's being said and find a path forward.

The assessments that I create typically require knowledge transfer, association, and experimental design, not recall. For example, in one quiz, students were presented with immunofluorescence data from stem cell-derived egg cells and asked to evaluate whether a protocol needed improvement. They had all necessary background, but needed to synthesize lecture concepts about epigenetic regulation with discussion material on stem cells. There was a correct answer, but reaching it required reasoning through the evidence presented, which is what scientists do when reading a paper.

Similarly, my homework questions ask students to design experiments in new scenarios. When asked to propose a method for detecting altered RNA splicing, I accepted RT-PCR, Northern blot, qPCR, or RNA-seq. Any valid approach with sound reasoning earns credit.

Throughout this process, I also maintain patience and curiosity with student's individual learning processes, with recent students describing me as a TA who "wanted [them] to really think" and made the classroom "a very comfortable place for students which encouraged [them] to ask a lot of questions."

With my aim to be a university professor, I am committed to continuous growth as an educator. I am currently designing a teaching-as-research study for CIRTL Scholar certification and pursuing CIRTL Associate certification through CEILS workshops on supporting neurodivergent students, "ungrading", and instructional demonstration.

Beyond the classroom, I have mentored four undergraduates: two over multiple years in my lab, guiding them from their sophomore through senior years on research projects, writing, presentations, and fellowship applications. I also mentored two undergraduates through UCLA's Biohackathon, where we developed a research proposal and poster that earned fourth place.

Teaching students to think like scientists is not always comfortable. Not for them or for me. Some students want the answer, and I ask them to find it. But when students write to me after the quarter ends, when I see them around campus, when they let me know through evaluations, or even when I see the lights turn on as they finally get a concept because they've worked through uncertainty, I know the process was worth it.

Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award 2026 Application: Teaching Philosophy
Isaias Roberson
Course: MCD Bio 144

I believe students learn best when they can construct their own understandings rather than being told how to think. Therefore, my role as an educator is not limited to delivering knowledge but creating conditions where students can build their own pathways to knowledge. I aim to foster an environment where students work through their confusion with me acting as a guide and a sounding board, rather than an authority figure who tells them what is right and wrong. When students create their own associations and arrive at an understanding through their own reasoning, they relate to knowledge differently. When they are forced to accept what I say, knowledge remains a collection of facts rather than something plastic that they can shape.

The Socratic Method

The foundation of my teaching is dialogue. In my discussion sections, I do not lecture. Instead, the classroom engages in conversation where both the students and I ask and answer questions. When students ask me what a figure means, I don't tell them. I ask what they notice. I tell them to trust what their eyes are telling them. I ask them to explain what they expect and then ask them to explain any differences between their expectations and what the data shows. At first this may feel uncomfortable, and students might want me to just give them the answer. But that shortcut removes the experience of figuring things out, which is the point. I aim to walk students through not understanding and get them to view it as the beginning of learning rather than a failure. "I don't understand" from a student will be met with a "what is confusing" from me, we clarify the point of confusion, and then I will guide the student back to the original question until they solve it themselves. This builds skills students will use long after graduation.

Modeling Critical Engagement with Scientific Literature

As a scientist, I know that published papers are not the final word on anything. Data can be weak. Conclusions can be overstated. Methods can have limitations the authors don't acknowledge. However, undergraduates may take scientific publications as law. Part of my job as an instructor is to model critical engagement for students. When we read a paper together, I don't just ask students what the authors concluded. I ask whether the data actually supports that conclusion. I ask what alternative explanations exist. I ask whether a figure is convincing or whether it leaves room for doubt.

This may feel awkward or daunting for students at first, as they may have learned that science is a collection of facts to memorize. But science is not a collection of facts. It is a process of inquiry, and that process requires skepticism, humility, and the willingness to disagree with experts when evidence warrants it. I want students to see that they are allowed to question what they read, that their interpretation matters, and that finding a different conclusion than the authors is not wrong if they can defend it. This training

serves students whether they become scientists, doctors, policymakers, or simply informed citizens evaluating claims in the news.

Adapting Mentorship as a Teacher

One privilege of being a scientist is mentoring people earlier in their journey. In the lab, I work with students for multiple years, meeting them where they are and then building their skills over time. Mentorship requires paying attention to each student's unique points of confusion and then addressing them directly. I try to adapt this investment within a 10-week quarter. Even in over-full discussion sections, I aim to notice where each student struggles and respond to that. I check in during office hours, follow up by email, or write notes in quiz or homework comments. Ensuring students feel supported is key at this stage of their journey.

Assessing Reasoning, Not Just Recall

Assessments should evaluate students' reasoning and support the varieties of thought processes present within a class, rather than trying to filter students all into one correct answer. The quizzes and exams that I design ask students to transfer their knowledge to new contexts, design experiments, and interpret data that they have never seen before given background. There is often a correct answer that students need to work towards, but the path they take can vary. I often state in the prompt that multiple approaches can work, so students don't feel anxious about "answering wrong." My rubrics reward reasoning: did the student understand the underlying principle and can they defend their approach?

Viewing Students as Scientists

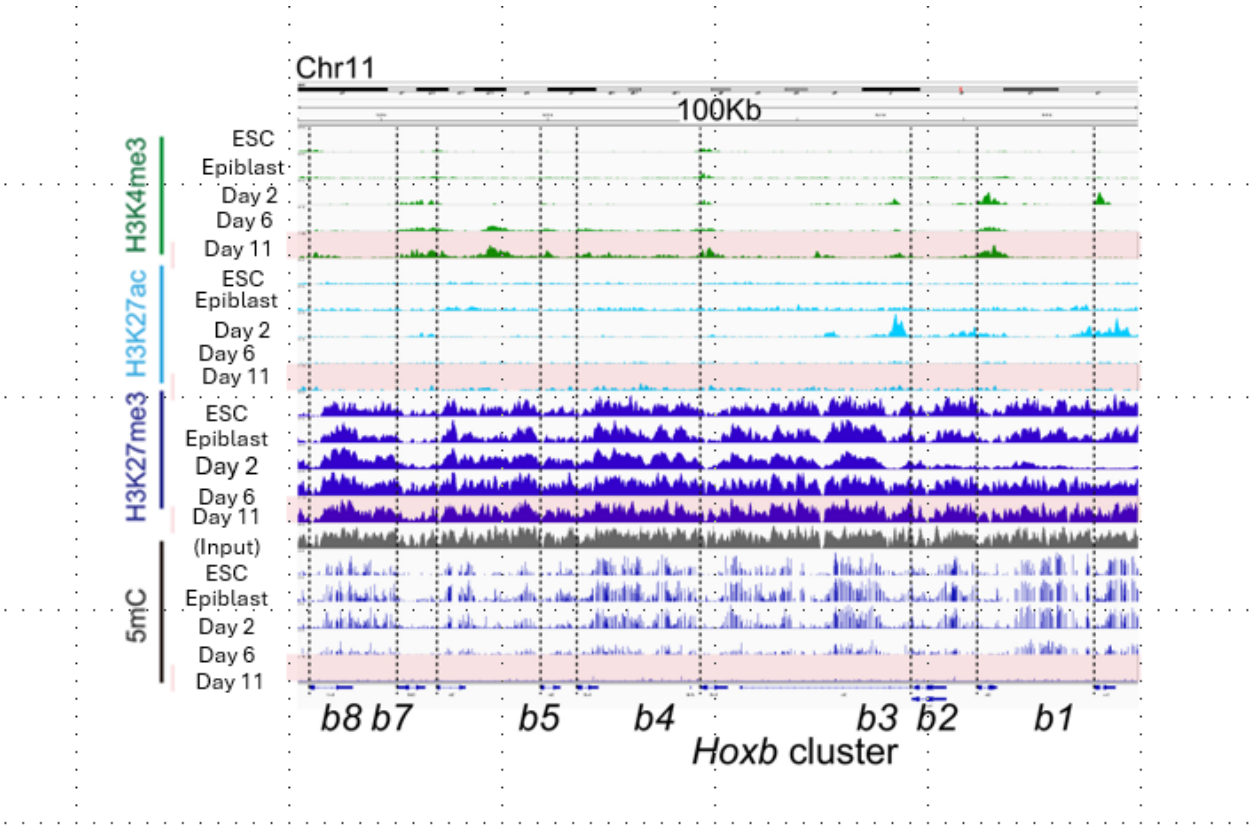
Finally, every student who enters my classroom already has what it takes to think like a scientist. They do not need to become someone else. They do not need to speak differently, dress differently, or hide parts of themselves to belong in science. My job is to create an environment where students feel empowered to take up space exactly as they are.

This means being clear there are no "stupid" questions. This means responding to wrong answers with curiosity rather than judgment. It means affirming students when they take intellectual risks, have a crazy idea, or think differently from their peers. When students see that their voice matters and their perspective is valued, they engage more deeply. They stop trying to figure out what I want to hear and start figuring out what they actually think.

My approach towards teaching students to think scientifically is not based on a high-throughput method. It would be faster to just tell them the answers or only provide

true/false questions. But my goal is not just to get them to master material. My goal is to get them to master themselves. The goal is metamorphosis: students who arrive afraid of research papers and leave confident they can read one; students who arrive waiting to be told what to think and leave trusting their own reasoning; students who arrive believing science is for other people and leave knowing it is for them.

DTA Annotation: *This is the class's 4th quiz of the quarter. Question 2 is one of the questions I authored. The question is structured to follow from correct data interpretation in part (1). Then students need to relate the context they are given in the prompt to what they have learned about DNA methylation in lecture and discussion for part (2). Part (3) follows from (1) and (2), where students should see that the stem cell-derived oocytes do not produce pronuclei with the correct methylation pattern, and given that, Rhea should revise her protocol, as the oocytes produced by it are aberrant. Students are provided all necessary background but must synthesize lecture and discussion material to reach the conclusion themselves. Students will recieve full credit for correct answer and reasoning, and 70% for proving reasoning, even if answer is wrong. This is in an effort to reward the thinking process, not only a correct answer.*



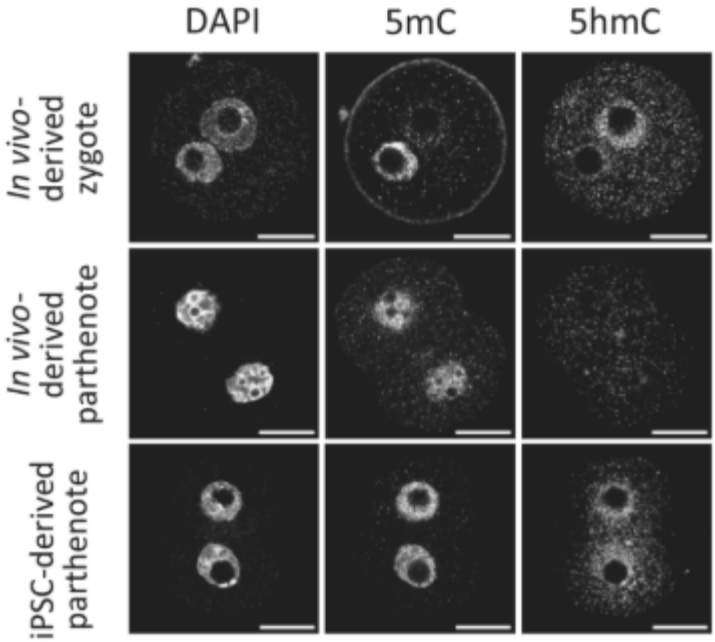
You are looking at ChIP and bisulfite-sequencing data of cells over the course of a differentiation. Note: 5mC in this graph is methylation of the cytosine base, not methylation on a histone tail.

a. Does this ChIP data of the Hoxb locus suggest the cells are repressing or expressing the Hoxb genes?

   Repressing genes. Low amounts of H3K27ac and high amounts of H3K27me3.

b. What does the methylation data suggest about what the cells are doing over the course of differentiation? Is the pattern of enrichment different than the other markers?

   The cells are demethylating their DNA but are maintaining repression of Hoxb locus through H3K27me3. Signal for 5mC is lost over time, whereas H3K27me3 is consistently high.



Rhea just created a protocol to develop oocytes (egg cells) from IPSCs. She's interested in studying how the IPSC-oocytes support early embryonic development.

Rhea knows that, normally, the oocyte's nucleus undergoes passive demethylation, meaning that the methylated cytosines (**5mC**) in the oocyte lose their methylation through subsequent cell divisions as the embryo develops. In contrast, the nucleus of the sperm cell undergoes active demethylation, in which 5mC is rapidly converted into 5-hydroxymethylcytosine (**5hmC**), which is subsequently converted to other unnatural cytosine bases, and ultimately, base excision repair replaces them with an unmethylated cytosine.

To study her IPSC-oocytes, Rhea is using three conditions: an in vivo-derived zygote produced from an oocyte and sperm fusion; a zygote produced from an in vivo oocyte that was activated without sperm (parthenote); and a zygote from an IPSC-derived oocyte that was activated without sperm (parthenote). Note that Rhea is using parthenotes to assess oocyte methylation status without sperm contribution.

Please help Rhea determine whether her oocyte production protocol needs improvement. To convince Rhea,

1. You will need to make sure you interpret the staining results from each of the three conditions. And specifically, how the IPSC condition compares to the in vivo conditions.

2. You will need to state what it might mean if there are issues in the epigenome of her IPSC oocytes based on your epigenetics knowledge from MCD 144.

3. Whether you think her protocol needs to be improved based on (1) and (2).

1. In the in vivo zygote from sperm+oocyte, we see 5mC in pronuclei from oocyte and 5hmC in pronuclei from sperm, indicating that oocyte pronuclei is undergoing passive demethylation and sperm pronuclei is undergoing active demethylation.

In the in vivo parthenote, we see both pronuclei labeled by 5mC antibody, indicating that there is only passive demethylation, as expected, as the zygote was produced in the absence of sperm.

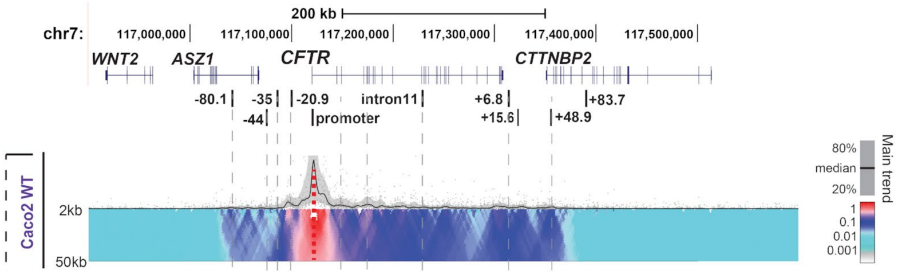
In the IPSC parthenote, we see 5mC and 5hmC on both pronuclei. Because pronuclei from oocytes should only be labeled by 5mC, and parthenotes are produced only from oocytes, this expression pattern indicates aberrant epigenetic regulation in IPSC-derived oocytes.

2. From MCD 144, we learned that DNA methylation prevents genes from being expressed. Based on what we see in the immunostaining, we can guess that when IPSC-derived oocytes fuse with sperm to produce a zygote, there is going to aberrant gene expression, as the oocyte pronuclei actively undergo active demethylation when they should only undergo passive demethylation. Therefore, genes may be prematurely expressed or expressed at levels they should not be.

3. Rhea should revise her oocyte derivation protocol, as the oocytes produced from IPSCs are not recapitulating the biology of the oocyte cell type.

Nikki is performing 4C-seq on Caco2 cells to determine the boundaries of a TAD for the gene *CFTR,* a gene for which mutations cause cystic fibrosis. The 4C contact profile below is shown for the Caco2 cells with the *CFTR* promoter as the viewpoint. The numbers below the genes listed with a +/- represent kilobases (kb) from the *CFTR* promoter.

a. Based on this figure, what sites would you designate as the boundaries for this TAD? How do you know?
b. Nikki also plans to perform ChIP-seq to determine if this region contains heterochromatin or euchromatin. Name two type of marks/proteins you might expect to see at the promoter if the chromatin were active.



a. -80.1 and +48.9 kb. The contact profile shows different colors to show the frequency that other sites contact the viewpoint/the promoter. The dark purple showing fairly frequent contacts with the promoter spreads from -80.1 to +48.9 kb.
b. Answers may vary but may include H3K4me3, H3K9ac, H3K27ac, RNA pol II

DTA Annotation: *This document shows the rubric I used when grading questions (2) and (3). Rather than listing a single correct answer, the rubric lists multiple valid experimental approaches students could use. For example, in question 2a, Southern blot, DNA FISH, or microarray would all be accepted. In question 3c, RT-PCR, Northern blot, qPCR with junction-spanning probes, or RNA-seq are all valid. Students earn full credit for any correct approach with sound reasoning. Students who demonstrate sound reasoning but arrive at an incorrect answer still receive 70% credit. This reflects my belief that assessments should evaluate thinking, not just correctness.*

MCDB 144 HW5

Instructions: *Please answer the questions below to the best of your ability. Keep your responses focused and concise. Once you answer the questions, if asked, provide rationale/evidence for your conclusion. Please make sure to write your responses in your own words; should any sentence read too closely to the paper you read, please place the content in quotes and refer to the paper as a reference.* ***Submit your report via the Bruinlearn submission link on Friday, November 21st, 2025, before 11:59pm.***

The following questions can be answered by referring to figures 1-3 of paper 6, lecture material, or previous papers.

1. **The success of retargeting hinges entirely on the reprogrammed RNA payload.**
    - **Compare the requirements for the R2Tg system to the traditional CRISPR-Cas9 system that we have discussed previously. While the Cas protein uses a guide RNA (gRNA) for targeting that is ~20 nt, the R2Tg system requires a much larger RNA payload (hundreds of nucleotides). Based on the mechanism we see in Figure 1a, why must the R2Tg RNA payload be so much longer than a gRNA? Reference at least two figure panels in your answer.**
        i. **CRISPR gRNA is only necessary for the guiding of the Cas protein to a target sequence to induce a double-stranded break. Part of the gRNA binds to the target DNA sequence and the other part of the gRNA serves as a scaffold for Cas9 to bind and cut that DNA at the desired site. If inserting a sequence through homology directed repair, a separate donor template must be included. On the other hand, the R2Tg payload has several roles that it needs to fulfill. One, the payload RNA must target a specific region via the homology arms that will bind to the target region and anchor the RNA to the nicked DNA for TPRT. In figure 2h, without homology arms, we do not see genomic integration. Two, it must have UTRs that are required to form conserved structures that bind and stabilize R2 proteins. In figure 2i, we see removing the 5' UTR results in lowered integration rate. Three, is that they must contain the actual template sequence that is to be inserted (such as Gluc in this case). They must also use at least two other panels that are not 1a, 1b, 2a, or 3a because those are schematics, which does not tell us anything about specific components being necessary.**
    - **Without the RNA payload, do you think that the R2Tg protein's RLE activity would have a weak or strong affinity for specific DNA on its own? Why? Use panel 3eto help you explain your answer.**
        i. **The R2Tg protein's RLE activity must have weak affinity for DNA on its own or have a non-sequence-specific activity. If it had strong affinity or sequence-specific affinity, even with the new homology arms, we would have likely seen cutting at the 28S locus and no cutting at the AAVS1 site in the top panel. If the RLE had sequence-specific or high affinity for a specific target, this would make reprogramming impossible. Instead, we see that using different homology arms is sufficient for retargeting the R2Tg to AAVS1. We**

see that the protein must be primarily guided to the target site based on the binding/annealing of the RNA homology arms to the target DNA, which helps position the RLE domain for nicking. Additionally, in the bottom panel, without the RNA template, we do not get cleavage. Again, this suggests that the homology arms/the RNA payload is necessary for targeting.

2. **Rasheed is experimenting with R2Tg. He differentiates neurons from IPSCs, and then he transfects his cells with an R2Tg-RNP complex, with homology arms for**
    - **OCT4 (Condition 1)**
    - **ATRX, a gene critical in maintaining neuronal health (Condition 2)**
    - **RNA28SN5, also known as 28S (Condition 3)**

Rasheed is interested in understanding R2Tg's behavior across the genome in his neurons, but he needs your help designing and interpreting his experiments.

a. **Using techniques you learned in MCDB 144 Lecture 10, please design an experiment that will indicate how many times R2Tg integrates into the neurons' genome.**
   Southern blot, DNA FISH, microarray, DNA sequencing
b. **Please state which condition(s) you expect to have the most integration and which condition(s) you expect to have the least integration, along with your reasoning as to why.**
   28s most, multiple copies, multiple instances of integration; OCT4 least, not expressed; ATRX intermediate, highly expressed but only 2 copies

3. **You want your cells to express Isoform B of Protein A more highly than Isoform A.**

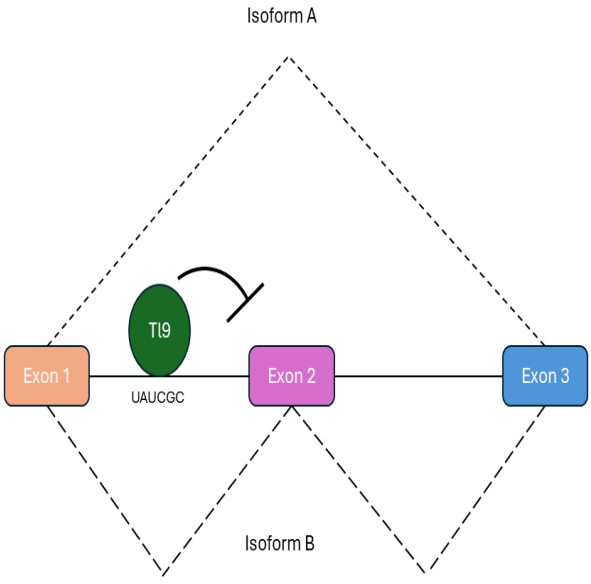


Figure Legend. Protein A is comprised of 3 exons. Isoform A synthesized from mRNA with only exon 1 and exon 3. Isoform B is synthesized from exons 1, 2 and 3. Tl9 is an RNA-binding protein that recognizes the UAUCGC on its target RNA molecules.

a. **Using what you know about R2Tg and scarless engineering, please design a gene editing experiment that will result in preferential expression of Isoform B. You will need to describe the payload you will use, including the order and configuration of the various RNA components such as the UTRs, the homology arms and your sequence of interest.**

5' UTR, 5' homology arm, 3' homology, 3'UTR. UTRs on outside to promote scarless integration, payload just excludes Tl9 binding site. RT2g will recombine locus based on homology arms.

b. **Please design an experiment that will show that the Protein A locus was successfully edited. State your expected results.**

DNA sequencing, Sanger sequencing, not PCR alone is not high enough resolution for this assay

c. **Please design an experiment that will show that the variant for Isoform B is preferentially produced. Please state your expected results.**

RT-PCR and then assess for differential migration in gel electrophoresis. Variant for Isoform B will migrate less than variant for Isoform A. Can also do Northern blot (variant for isoform B will migrate less than variant for isoform A). Can also perform qPCR using probes that span exon 1-2 junction for Isoform B variant and probes that span exon 1-3 junction for Isoform A variant. Could also perform RNA-seq.

d. **Please design an experiment that will show that Isoform B is preferentially produced. Please state your expected results.**

Western blot and difference in migration due to molecular weight between Isoform B and A, compare band intensities. Can say IF with antibodies specific for exon 2 peptides. Will need to compare mutant to WT. Can also say an antibody strategy similar to exon 1-2 and exon 1-3 junction strategy in part C, where antibodies will be raised to peptides spanning the junctions for 1-2 and 1-3 to identify Isoform B and A peptide sequences, respectively

Student Evaluation of Teaching: Selected Excerpts

MCD BIO 144: Molecular Biology of Cellular Processes
Discussion Sections 1C & 1D, Spring 2023 and Fall 2025
Total respondents: 69 students

Creating Space for Intellectual Risk-Taking Through Patience and Understanding

A central goal of my teaching is helping students engage productively with uncertainty—to offer interpretations of data even when they're not certain they're 'right.' And maintain patience as students are working through uncertainty.

> *"He did a great job creating a comfortable environment to encourage participation even if we weren't entirely confident in our answers. He wrote fair and thought-provoking quiz questions."* — Spring 2023

> *"I appreciate him not pressuring me to attempt to answer a question I had said I was unsure of. It made me feel as though it is ok to not know everything that is being discussed in our dense research papers."* — Spring 2023

> *"I felt so supported by him throughout this entire quarter. Sometimes it is a little hard for me to follow along with his explanations, but he never seemed to get frustrated and always supported my learning."* — Fall 2025

Encouraging Critical Thinking Over Answer-Finding

Rather than telling students what a paper concludes, I push them to interpret data themselves and evaluate whether the evidence supports the authors' claims.

> *"When we have questions about papers, he will lead us to think instead of just telling us answers. He will also emphasize important figures that we need to understand their methods and results."* — Fall 2025

> *"Isaias was amazing—always so knowledgeable and wanted us to really think. He always made himself available to our questions."* — Fall 2025

> *"TA Roberson helps concisely clarify what the paper's main points are and attempts to make us think further about why the experiments discussed are of value."* — Spring 2023

Making Complex Material Accessible

MCD BIO 144 requires students to read and interpret dense primary literature. As an educator, its my role to meet students where they are in their scientific journey and communicate in a way that bridges where they are currently and where they will be at the end of the course.

> *"He explains concepts very well and makes them easy to understand."* — Spring 2023

> *"The TA provided engaging presentations that did a good job breaking down the difficult assigned papers. They also did a great job explaining technical information presented in these papers."* — Spring 2023

> *"He made the papers that were covered in discussion seem easy. It was nice that we went over lab techniques and how they work as we don't go in depth about in lecture."* — Fall 2025

Accessibility and Genuine Care for Student Learning

I genuinely want students to succeed and take advantage of the resources available. I try my best to work with students to remove as many barriers to their learning as possible.

> *"Very personable, approachable, clearly interested in student success, explains difficult concepts well."* — Spring 2023
>
> *"I really appreciated his patience and affable character. His innumerable efforts to facilitate things to the best of his abilities have not gone unnoticed by either myself or my peers."* — Spring 2023
>
> *"He was extremely approachable, knowledgeable about the subject, and engaged during our discussion sections. He seemed to genuinely care about the students and their learning experience. It was an absolute pleasure to attend his discussion section."* — Fall 2025

Evidence of Growth

My overall TA ratings improved from the first time teaching in Spring 2023 and to my most recent completed quarter in Fall 2025, reflecting ongoing development in my teaching practice:

Metric	Spring 2023	Fall 2025
Overall TA Rating (mean, 1–9 scale)	7.52–8.09	7.85–8.40
"TA was concerned about student learning"	8.19–8.50	7.92–8.36
"Students felt welcome seeking help"	8.24–8.45	7.77–8.50

Note: All excerpts are were taken from official UCLA Student Experience of Teaching (SET) surveys administered at the end of each quarter.

Thank You!

External Inbox ×

DTA Annotation: Included with permission.

Jillian Sarquiz <jillsarquiz@gmail.com> Thu, Jun 22, 2023, 1:12 PM

to me ▾ Listen

Hi Isaias,

I hope you are having a great summer!

I wanted to thank you for a great quarter. You have been a wonderful TA, and I'm surprised that this was your first time as a TA considering how well you teach and interact with students. I always looked forward to going to your discussion section because you always brought such a positive attitude towards learning. I enjoyed your comical subtle comments about the papers and your explanation on zodiac signs. You made the classroom a very comfortable place for students which encouraged me to ask a lot of questions.

I appreciate how kind and patient you have always been with me during discussion and office hours. You allowed me to say "no I still don't understand this concept," when I typically would have just nodded and agreed when a professor or TA explained a concept to me. You have been such an important part of my learning in this class, and I'm proud to say I am no longer afraid of research papers.

Thank you again for being an awesome TA, and hopefully I'll see you around campus!

Best,
Jillian Sarquiz

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

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Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

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Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

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Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

Isaias Roberson was my teaching assistant for MCDB 144 with Professor Diana Rigueur during Spring 2023. From the first day, he created a supportive and approachable learning environment in a challenging course. His clear explanations and genuine investment in student success left a lasting impact that I still remember three years later. (49)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Isaias played a significant role in inspiring me to pursue molecular biology as a long-term research path. Beyond teaching course material, he generously shared his experiences in graduate school, spoke openly about his research, and answered my many questions about what a career in science truly looks like. As an undergraduate, I initially entered UCLA as pre-med, but during my upper-division MCDB courses, I began reconsidering my path. Conversations with Isaias were instrumental in helping me shift toward pursuing a PhD.

I was especially inspired by his research environment and the work of his PI, Dr. Amander Clark, whose lab I later listed as one of my interests when applying to the MBI PhD program. She ultimately interviewed me for the program. Without Isaias' guidance and encouragement, I may not have explored doctoral programs or her research as seriously as I did.

Three years later, I am now a PhD student in the MBI program at UCLA. Isaias not only helped shape that decision but continues to check in and offer support as I navigate graduate school and research. (195)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Going into MCDB 144, I knew it had a reputation as one of the more challenging core courses in the major. One of the steepest learning curves for me was interpreting the dense primary literature assigned throughout the quarter. As an aspiring scientist, I genuinely wanted to understand these complex papers, but they initially felt overwhelming. Isaias helped change that.

I remember our first major paper was Yamanaka's breakthrough Cell paper on induced pluripotent stem cells. Isaias made what seemed intimidating feel approachable. He carefully walked us through each figure, often selecting the most complex ones to dissect as a group. He did more than summarize results; he connected experimental design to the molecular biology concepts we were learning in lecture with Dr. Rigueur. This helped me see how techniques translate into real scientific discovery.

He also challenged us with simple but powerful questions, such as why the authors chose specific assays and what conclusions each experiment truly supported. These discussions strengthened my analytical thinking and helped me understand not just what the data showed, but why the experiments mattered. His guidance improved my confidence in reading scientific literature and shaped how I approach research today. (197)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

I believe Isaias is an outstanding candidate for this award because he genuinely cares about student learning, engagement, and long-term success beyond the course. As a current TA in the MCDB department, I understand the level of preparation and balance required to excel in both teaching and research. Isaias handled this seamlessly. He was consistently prepared, present, and approachable, creating an environment where students felt comfortable asking any question. His dedication to teaching never felt secondary to his research responsibilities, which speaks to both his professionalism and commitment to student growth. (99)

Atsushi Nakano, MD, Ph.D.
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Feb 03, 2026

RE: Isaias Roberson

Dear Committee:

It is a great pleasure and honor for me to recommend **Isaias Roberson** for the Award for Teaching Excellence. I am having the opportunity to work closely with Isaias in my MCDB144 Molecular Biology class this Winter. This is an upper division class that provides highly motivated students the knowledge and way of thinking about molecular biology. The course covers advanced topics in genomics, gene regulation, epigenetics, cell cycle, cancer, apoptosis and stem cells. Approximately ~60 students are well prepared for taking this class, with significant amount of the lab experience and top grades in pre-requisite LS molecular and/or cell biology courses. In this demanding academic environment, Isaias was responsible for Discussion Sections 1C and 1D, attending the lectures, and assisting with the development of the course materials, including homework assignemnts and the Midterm Exam. His contributions are instrumental in ensuring that the course runs smoothly and effectively.

Isaias, with his soft tone, always creates a welcoming atmosphere. Every week, he spends time to read the paper and prepare the note for the discussion. He fully digests the content of the lectures and papers before his discussion section starts. He helped me make homework and midterm exam. His questions are targeted right to the conceptrual sweet spot, addressing the topics that students must understand but often found challenging. He constantly contributes to meaningful, high-quality materials to our shared course resources. This reflects his comprehensive grasp of the lecture materials and the keen awareness of the students' learning needs. , as well as the skill to effectively deliver it to the students.

Beyond his teaching abilities, Isaias is concerned about the students and incredibly reliable and proactive. He spends time to make sure the students fully understdand. He offered to take on extra responsibilities, such as hosting a review session before the exam and even uploading the video recording for the students who could not attend. His commitment to mentorship and ability to foster community among students will make impact on students' learning.

Students appreciate how he communicates and interacts with them. I hear their voice, such as, “he is organized”, “great structure for the discussion section”, “he welcomes all questions and genuinely just wants us to learn”.

An approachable, dedicated and effective TA is essential for the students’ success. Isaias exemplifies these qualities. He is an outstanding TA who truly cares about the students learning and growth. I give him my strongest recommendation for this year’s Teaching Excellence Award.

Sincerely,



Atsushi Nakano (Austin), Feb 03, 2026